ED taken up paper leak cases in states ruled by the BJP?" The bluster aside, the CM could be in a spot of bother if the agency proves the involvement of politicians perceived to be close to him and his Rajiv Gandhi Study Circle (RGSC). Some members of the RGSC were coordinators for the REET.

The credit for the raids goes to Kirori Lal Meena, the 71-year-old BJP Rajya Sabha MP who has been fighting a lone battle on this front (the party's state organisation has not backed him on this), playing up what he offers as evidence and even naming alleged suspects. Meena's crusading has been relentless. Just last week, he lodged another complaint with the ED alleging corruption in the department of information technology (DoIT), event management and digital publicity. Last month's accidental recovery of Rs 2.3 crore in cash and a 1 kg gold bar from a cabinet in the department's offices (traced back to a joint director-rank officer) has led to a chorus of demands for a thorough investigation.

What has stirred the cauldron further is dissident Congress leader Sachin Pilot following Meena in demanding a probe in the paper leaks case. He also wants compensation for candidates who wrote the cancelled tests—a demand Gehlot earlier called proof of "mental bankruptcy". Pilot was busy last weekend at commemoration events for his father and Congress leader, the late Rajesh Pilot. At a rally in Dausa later, he reiterated the twin demands he has been pursuing of late—nailing the culprits of the paper leaks case as well as the mines allotment scandal during BJP chief minister Vasundhara Raje's tenure. Now, since that gets both Gehlot and Raje in the crosshairs—putting his own party government on the same ethical footing as the previous Raje regime—speculation abounds on who that confers an advantage on. The ex-CM's loyalists naturally interpret that to be the anti-Raje saffron camp, and read Pilot's moves as being in alignment with their needs. Pilot merely says, "Corruption in the system is unpardonable and I am not targeting anyone when I raise this issue."

The Congress high command had a meeting with both leaders in Delhi on May 29 and declared a truce saying the party would contest elections under their dual leadership.

WITH ALL RELIGIONS Sachin Pilot at a prayer meeting in Dausa, June 11 ▼



TWITTER@SACHIN PILOT

PILOT'S RESTRAINT SINCE THE HIGH COMMAND FORCED A TRUCE HAS NOT SETTLED THE ENDGAME

Since then, even while reiterating his demands, Pilot has let his "May-end deadline" pass and avoided any aggression at the June 11 rally. His supporters also underplayed the event, calling it an annual affair for Pilot Sr.

Gehlot has been even more restrained since the truce. The high command seems to have told both leaders that its word will be final on all matters. So even if Pilot stays on in the Congress—which, at the moment, seems the best option for him—he stares at the possibility of being surpassed again if Gehlot leads the Congress to a win. Only a loss could see Pilot wangle the leader of the opposition post, with its prestige and perks. For now, the BJP is unlikely to make a move to get him onboard as a potential chief ministerial contender. It's happy with Pilot being a dissident in the Congress or even floating his own party. There were strong rumours of this before the Dausa event, and even Congress leaders who poohpoohed the idea may have been relieved that it didn't come to pass.

Gehlot is from the Mali caste. It has little political influence in the state, but, of late, they have been mobilising to counter Pilot's Gujjar community. Malis, Gujjars and Jats are the dominant OBC castes in the state but they rarely vote as one entity. Today, no leader can claim to be a leader of all the OBCs in the state. Around October, it will be clear if the dissidents in either party are a force to reckon with.

Meanwhile, CM Gehlot is out in the field to assess the impact of the 'inflation relief camps' he launched in April. His best bet for a second term is still his bouquet of social welfare schemes and freebies—he'll be looking to jog the voters' memory at every possible opportunity. The CM has, at the behest